Unification

Concepts of Programming Languages

CAS CS 320

Recap

Recall: Constraint-Based Inference

$$\Gamma \vdash e : \tau \dashv \mathscr{C}$$

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The constraint-based type inference process:

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The constraint-based type inference process:

1. Derive $\Gamma \vdash e : \tau$ *relative to some constraints* $\mathscr{C}$

Recall: Constraint-Based Inference

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The constraint-based type inference process:

1. Derive $\Gamma \vdash e : \tau$ *relative to some constraints* $\mathscr{C}$
2. Use the $\mathscr{C}$ to determine the "actual" type of e in Γ

Recall: Constraint-Based Inference

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The constraint-based type inference process:

1. Derive $\Gamma \vdash e : \tau$ *relative to some constraints* $\mathscr{C}$
2. Use the $\mathscr{C}$ to determine the "actual" type of e in Γ today (and next week)

Recall: HM$^-$ (Typing)

$$\frac{n \texttt{ is an integer}}{\Gamma \vdash n : \mathsf{int} \dashv \varnothing} \ \texttt{(int)}$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash e_1 : \tau_1 \dashv \mathscr{C}_1 \qquad \Gamma \vdash e_2 : \tau_2 \dashv \mathscr{C}_2 \qquad \Gamma \vdash e_3 : \tau_3 \dashv \mathscr{C}_3}{\Gamma \vdash \mathsf{if}\ e_1\ \mathsf{then}\ e_2\ \mathsf{else}\ e_3 : \tau_3 \dashv \tau_1 \doteq \mathsf{bool}, \tau_2 \doteq \tau_3, \mathscr{C}_1, \mathscr{C}_2, \mathscr{C}_3} \ \texttt{(if)}$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash e_1 : \tau_1 \dashv \mathscr{C}_1 \qquad \Gamma \vdash e_2 : \tau_2 \dashv \mathscr{C}_2}{\Gamma \vdash e_1 = e_2 : \mathsf{bool} \dashv \tau_1 \doteq \tau_2, \mathscr{C}_1, \mathscr{C}_2} \ \texttt{(eq)}$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash e_1 : \tau_1 \dashv \mathscr{C}_1 \qquad \Gamma \vdash e_2 : \tau_2 \dashv \mathscr{C}_2}{\Gamma \vdash e_1 + e_2 : \mathsf{int} \dashv \tau_1 \doteq \mathsf{int}, \tau_2 \doteq \mathsf{int}, \mathscr{C}_1, \mathscr{C}_2} \ \texttt{(add)}$$

$$\frac{\alpha \texttt{ is fresh} \qquad \Gamma, x : \alpha \vdash e : \tau \dashv \mathscr{C}}{\Gamma \vdash \lambda x . e : \alpha \to \tau \dashv \mathscr{C}} \ \texttt{(fun)}$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash e_1 : \tau_1 \dashv \mathscr{C}_1 \qquad \Gamma \vdash e_2 : \tau_2 \dashv \mathscr{C}_2 \qquad \alpha \texttt{ is fresh}}{\Gamma \vdash e_1 e_2 : \alpha \dashv \tau_1 \doteq \tau_2 \to \alpha, \mathscr{C}_1, \mathscr{C}_2} \ \texttt{(app)}$$

Recall: What is a constraint?

$$\tau_1 \doteq \tau_2$$

A **type constraint** is a predicate on types. The only kind we will consider:

"τ_1 should be the same as τ_2"

Enforcing a constraint like this is called **unifying** τ_1 and τ_2

Unification

High Level

$$
\begin{aligned}
a &\doteq d \to e \\
c &\doteq \mathsf{int} \to d \\
\mathsf{int} \to \mathsf{int} \to \mathsf{int} &\doteq b \to c
\end{aligned}
$$

Unification is the process of solving a system of equations over *symbolic* expressions

Type Unification

$\sigma ::= \text{int} \mid \text{bool} \mid \alpha \mid \sigma \to \sigma$

A **type unification problem** is a collection of equations of the form

$$\begin{aligned} s_1 &\doteq t_1 \\ s_2 &\doteq t_2 \\ &\vdots \\ s_k &\doteq t_k \end{aligned}$$

where $s_1, \ldots, s_k$ and $t_1, \ldots, t_k$ are types

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where $\mathscr{S} t = [t_n/x_n] \ldots [t_1/x_1] t$

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Most General Unifiers

A **most general unifier** is a solution $\mathcal{S}$ such that, for any solution $\mathcal{S}'$, there is another solution $\mathcal{S}''$ such that $\mathcal{S}'\tau = \mathcal{S}''\mathcal{S}\tau$

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In other words, $\mathcal{S}'$ is $\mathcal{S}$ *with more substitutions*

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- (F) function type equality (e.g., $\alpha \to \beta \doteq \alpha \to \gamma$)

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Assignment become *part of our solution*

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Assignment become *part of our solution*

We're guaranteed to get the a most general unifier

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in: type unification problem 𝒰
out: most general unifier for 𝒰
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    (S) $t \doteq t \implies \mathcal{U} \leftarrow \mathcal{U} \backslash \{eq\}$ // if *syntactically* equal then remove eq

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    (F) s₁ → t₁ ≐ s₂ → t₂ ⟹ 𝒰 ← 𝒰\{eq} ∪ {s₁ ≐ s₂, t₁ ≐ t₂} // remove eq and add s₁ ≐ s₂ and t₁ ≐ t₂

    (A) α ≐ t or t ≐ α where α ∉ FV(t) ⟹ // type variable α does not appear free in t
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    (A) $\alpha \doteq t$ or $t \doteq \alpha$ where $\alpha \notin \mathsf{FV}(t) \implies$ // type variable α does not appear free in t

      $\mathcal{S} \leftarrow \mathcal{S} \cup \{\alpha \mapsto t\}$ // add $\alpha \mapsto t$ to $\mathcal{S}$

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      perform the substitution $\alpha \mapsto t$ to every equation in $\mathcal{U}$

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    OTHERWISE $\implies$ **FAIL**

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RETURN $\mathcal{S}$

Example

$$a \doteq d \to e$$

$$c \doteq \mathsf{int} \to d$$

$$\mathsf{int} \to \mathsf{int} \to \mathsf{int} \doteq b \to c$$

Unification may Fail

$$a \doteq b \to c$$
$$b \doteq a \to \mathsf{int}$$

workshop